is a prime example of what a structured and competitive sporting culture at the grassroots levels can yield on the big stage. Sample this—the athletes who are part of the NCAA system from across 12 nations won a total of 60 medals at the Paris Olympic Games. Jamaica has the Champs—a nationwide inter-school athletics meet that is responsible for world champions like Shelly-Ann Fraser-Pryce, Usain Bolt and Yohan Blake, among so many others.

Closer home, cricket has cracked the system of producing players from school competitions. The Harris and Giles shields—two of the country's premier inter-school competitions in Mumbai, have produced some of the greatest cricketers—not just in India, but worldwide. School tournaments work as nurseries to generate talent.

We need to replicate this with Olympic sporting disciplines, and it will be a matter of time before we can begin scouting and recruiting very talented youngsters who can then be honed with the help of a professional programme. What this will also do is give rise to the number of coaches with a high degree of quality. A competitive structure at the school level will automatically push these institutions to produce and recruit better coaches.



The direction to take: There is no single answer to the oft-repeated question of what it would take for India to be a global sporting superpower, but there is a direction that will get us there. A competitive, structured grassroots programme and a robust public-private partnership model where everyone involved is singing from the same song sheet, is our surest way to success. JSW Sports is in its third Olympic cycle, and I speak from a place of having experienced the benefits of corporate India working in tandem with the federations. The Inspire Institute of Sport aside, we have always gone above and beyond to be of use to federations that need expertise, aid or fillip. We have been supporting the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) since 2019 and, at the time of writing this piece, all three of India's medals in Paris have come from our shooters. This isn't just happenstance. We've lent the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) our expertise in terms of technical support. A concentrated, consistent and collective push—that's what it will take to keep moving the needle of India's sporting ambitions.

If you're someone who has been following Indian sports, you will admit that the change in landscape has been encouraging, if not seismic. Our athletes aren't satisfied qualifying for global events anymore. They believe they can win them. There is a switch in mentality, and it is infectious. Neeraj Chopra, Lakshya Sen, Manu Bhaker, all walk into an arena with the kind of confidence and aura that champions possess.

When it comes to statistics and perspective, our population always finds a mention in relation to the medals we win at the Olympic Games, or when it comes to our FIFA ranking in world football. Our numbers are our strength, but only if we reach them. Our programmes need to cover the length and breadth of the country. We need a solid talent scouting system and a network of quality coaches making sure that no talent slips through the system. Add the application of sports science and access to high-performance facilities to the mix, and the results will begin speaking for themselves.

Building the fan base: The general awareness around the Indian athlete has risen rapidly. Broadcasters in India are bringing global events to people's homes because they're sensing the interest. Just like our athletes, the Indian sports fan, too, needs to be built, and the onus is on all stakeholders to capitalise on the work being put in by the corporates, federations and government by weaving and showcasing a narrative that is unfolding in Indian sport. Corporate India has come forward in a big way, and federations, too, have become welcoming of the support. However, if we are to achieve the standards we dream of, this push must increase a hundred-fold. We have a responsibility to take our nation where we want to see it on the global sporting map, because India's athletes aren't just showing up, they are turning up, and so must we. ■

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